Hedonism

Phil 101 · Day 19

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Where we are

Tuesday’s question

What is a good life? What things are good *for* the person whose life it is?

Today we’ll look at a very simple and very old answer: what’s good for a person is pleasure in the absence of pain. On the theory we’re going to look at, nothing else matters.

Two separate claims

Psychological hedonism

As a matter of fact, people always pursue their own pleasure.

Evaluative hedonism

Pleasure is the only thing that is good for a person.

The first of these seems pretty clearly false. People will make enormous sacrifices for things they care about.

The hedonist view says that these really are sacrifices. When someone makes their life less pleasant defending a cause they care about, they make themselves worse off, though they may, of course, make the world better off.

What is pleasure, though?

This turns out to be a surprisingly hard question.

A simple answer is that pleasure is a feeling, a feeling that eating chocolate, lying in the sun, having a hot shower, understanding a poem, and any other pleasant thing has in common.

The obvious problem is it's not clear what feelings these have in common. They are all positive feelings in various ways, but that's not the same thing as being the same kind of feeling.

The other answer

So sometimes pleasure is defined not as being a kind of feeling, but as being a feeling that the person who has it likes. An experience is pleasant when you like it, when you want it to go on.

One worry, which we'll mostly set aside for now, is that this seems to be turning the view into something like a preference satisfaction view of welfare. That's the view we're going to talk about in more detail next Tuesday.

But just to give you a flavour of the worry: if what's good about pleasures is that we want them, then we might wonder why other things that we want, which are not experiences, aren't also good.

Bentham

Bentham

Nature has placed mankind under the governance of two sovereign masters, pain and pleasure.

For Bentham, the only things that mattered about pleasures were:

1. How intense the pleasure is; and
2. How long it lasts for

What’s attractive about this

The nice thing about this is that it’s clear why these considerations matter.

If pleasures are good, then it’s better that they be stronger and longer.

The problem, and it’s one we saw already with Mill, is that it seems to be a bit crude.

Mill's amendment

Mill thought Bentham's version was too crude, and added a third dimension: quality.

> **Mill**
>
> It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied.

Some pleasures are *higher*. Poetry really is better than a sugar buzz, and not because there's more pleasure in it.

The trouble with the amendment

Just as we saw when we tried to define pleasure, the worry is now that we've changed to a preference satisfaction theory.

If what makes the higher pleasures more valuable is that we want them, then we're again saying that what's really important to people is that they get what they want.

And as we noted before, there are many things people want other than experiences. So it's unclear why we should go along with the hedonist who says that only experiences matter to welfare.

The philosophy of swine

When Mill introduced this worry, the problem was that human lives might be no better than pig lives if pleasure is all that matters.

It might not even be anything as complicated as a pig. In the reading, Crisp suggests that an oyster with a long enough life could have as good a life as a human.

Whether this is a reason to reject the view, or a fascinating discovery we've made about the nature of welfare, I'll leave for you to decide.

Evil pleasures

Some people worry that pleasures that people get from evil deeds count too highly on this view.

The pleasure that the torturer gets in torturing his victims will both make his life better and, if well-being is important to morality, make the world a better place.

It's important here to separate the questions of whether it's good for the torturer that he is happy when torturing his victims from the question of whether it's good for the world that the torturer is happy when torturing his victims. You can say that the first is true and the second is false, and many philosophers have.

The experience machine

The machine

In the middle of a book about political philosophy, the libertarian philosopher Robert Nozick introduced this example, which was probably more influential than his broader libertarianism.

Nozick

Suppose there were an experience machine that would give you any experience that you desired. Superduper neuropsychologists could stimulate your brain so that you would think and feel you were writing a great novel, or making a friend, or reading an interesting book. All the time you would be floating in a tank, with electrodes attached to your brain. Should you plug into this machine for life, preprogramming your life's experiences?

Why Not Plug In?

Nozick

If you are worried about missing out on desirable experiences, we can suppose that business enterprises have researched thoroughly the lives of many others. You can pick and choose from their large library or smorgasbord of such experiences, selecting your life's experiences for, say, the next two years. [Then you reset every two years.] …

Would you plug in? What else can matter to us, other than how our lives feel from the inside? Nor should you refrain because of the few moments of distress between the moment you've decided and the moment you're plugged. What's a few moments of distress compared to a lifetime of bliss (if that's what you choose), and why feel any distress at all if your decision is the best one?

iClicker POLL

Would you plug in for life?

A. Yes
B. No
C. Only if the people I care about plugged in too
D. I'd want to know more about the machine first

Nozick’s three reasons

Nozick says we wouldn’t, and gives three reasons why not.

We want to do things, not merely to have the experience of doing them. The machine gives you the feeling of writing a novel. That is not the same as writing one.

We want to be a certain way. Nobody floating in a tank is courageous, or kind, or funny.

We want contact with something we didn’t make. The machine confines you to a reality built by other people.

What the argument shows

If any one of those three is right, then something other than experience matters to how your life goes.

Even if pleasure is a big part of welfare, this shows it isn't *everything*.

What it doesn’t show

It doesn’t tell you which theory is right. The question of what welfare really is would still be open.

Also, there’s a step in Nozick’s argument that we should pay attention to.

He argues from the fact that we wouldn’t plug in to the fact that we’d not improve our well-being by plugging in.

If we are systematically wrong about what our welfare is, these things might come apart.

If we don’t think that welfare is just preference satisfaction, then presumably that’s because we think people are often wrong about their own well-being.

Three replies a hedonist can make

It's status quo bias. Turn the question around and ask if you would unplug yourself if you found you had been living in a machine all along.

The paradox of hedonism. Even hedonists think we shouldn't only care about pleasure. One strange thing about pleasure is that aiming for it directly is often not the best way to get it. Maybe the fact that we wouldn't plug into the machine just shows that we are well designed for living in a world where you have to aim at pleasure indirectly.

And a worry about method. Maybe the fact that the theory has been supported by so many people for so long should make us cautious about giving it up because of one example.

Next

Tuesday

If not pleasure, then what?

The next answer is that welfare is getting what you want. This is the standard answer in economics for much of its history. But it has troubles of its own, especially with other-directed preferences, and preferences you'll never find out whether they are met.

Reading: SEP §4.2.